

WOWING AMERICA

On his return from a successful tour of Europe, Wilbur Wright made a demonstration flight, on October 4, 1909, along the Hudson river from Governor's Island in New York Harbor to President Grant's tomb and back, witnessed by over a million spectators.



their airplanes, they spent much of their energy on legal action against their competitors in Europe and the United States for infringement of patents. Their most bitterly fought case, against Glenn Curtiss, dragged on until 1914. Curtiss retaliated by taking part in an attempt, backed by the Smithsonian Institution, to prove that Samuel Pierpont Langley should be credited with creating the first viable flying machine. The endless litigation undermined Wilbur's morale and health and he died suddenly of typhoid fever in 1912. Orville continued aeronautical research, but his relationship with the Wright company ended in 1915. He stayed in Dayton, living long enough to see the Smithsonian finally, in 1943, accept the Wrights' claim to have been the first to fly.

**AT THE WHITE HOUSE**

This photograph shows US president William Howard Taft, flanked by Wilbur, Orville, and Katherine Wright, standing on the White House terrace after an honors ceremony in 1909. Wilbur and Orville received the Congressional gold medal (right) the same year.

**SLOW WORK**

The Wright brothers' increasing fame led to a steady string of orders for flying machines from their factory in Dayton, Ohio. This picture shows a wing under construction – the wooden frame is being covered with cloth – a labor-intensive and painstaking business.

